

# Jeremiah 1 - 3

## *Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)*

Tonight we begin Jeremiah at the beginning - with a young man told he was known before he was formed, a courtroom where Yahweh puts His own conduct on trial, and a wife the law says cannot come home who is told to come home anyway.

A boy who says he cannot speak, and a hand that touches his mouth.

A people who traded a spring of living water for cisterns they cracked themselves.

A God who writes the divorce certificate and then, against every legal precedent He Himself gave, says "return again to me."

Jeremiah 1 is the call - the commission, the two visions, and the promise that turns a frightened young priest into a fortified city.

Jeremiah 2 is the covenant lawsuit, where Yahweh does something startling: instead of listing charges first, He asks what He did wrong. "What unrighteousness have your fathers found in me?" The indictment only lands after the question has been left hanging.

Jeremiah 3 takes the lawsuit into the most painful room in the house - the marriage - and there, where the case is strongest and the verdict most deserved, mercy interrupts the proceedings.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

# CHAPTER 1 - The Call, the Almond Branch, and the Boiling Pot

## Key Notes

- The book is dated precisely - the thirteenth year of Josiah through the eleventh year of Zedekiah, to the captivity of Jerusalem. Jeremiah's ministry spans roughly forty years and five kings (Jeremiah 1:1-3).
- Yahweh's commission reaches backward before Jeremiah existed: known, sanctified, and appointed a prophet to the nations before he was formed in the womb (Jeremiah 1:4-5).
- Jeremiah objects on the grounds of youth and inability - "I don't know how to speak; for I am a child" - and Yahweh does not argue with the self-assessment. He simply overrides it with a command and a promise (Jeremiah 1:6-8).
- Yahweh touches his mouth: the words will not be Jeremiah's own. The authority of the message rests on its source, not on the speaker's eloquence (Jeremiah 1:9).
- The commission is sixfold and deliberately lopsided - four verbs of demolition, two of construction: to uproot, tear down, destroy, overthrow, build, and plant (Jeremiah 1:10).
- First vision, the almond branch: a Hebrew wordplay that does not survive translation. The almond (shaqed) is the watcher (shoqed) - the first tree to wake in late winter. Yahweh is watching over His word to perform it (Jeremiah 1:11-12).
- Second vision, the boiling cauldron tipping from the north: the direction from which every invader historically came down into Judah, and the direction of the coming Babylonian judgment (Jeremiah 1:13-16).
- The chapter ends with the promise that carries the whole book: a fortified city, an iron pillar, bronze walls. Not exemption from the fight - guaranteed survival of it (Jeremiah 1:17-19).

## Key Cross-References (WEB)

| Topic                              | References                                                                                        |
|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Known and Set Apart Before Birth   | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:5</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 139:13-16</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 49:1</a>      |
| The Prophet's Protest of Inability | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:6</a> • <a href="#">Exodus 4:10</a> • <a href="#">Judges 6:15</a>          |
| The Mouth Touched, the Words Given | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:9</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 6:6-7</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 3:1-3</a>       |
| To Uproot and to Plant             | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:10</a> • <a href="#">Jeremiah 18:7-10</a> • <a href="#">Jeremiah 31:28</a> |
| The Almond - the Watching Tree     | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:11-12</a> • <a href="#">Numbers 17:8</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 55:11</a>    |
| Evil Out of the North              | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:14</a> • <a href="#">Jeremiah 4:6</a> • <a href="#">Jeremiah 6:1</a>       |
| A Fortified City, an Iron Pillar   | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:18</a> • <a href="#">Jeremiah 15:20</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 50:7</a>      |
| They Will Not Prevail Against You  | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:19</a> • <a href="#">Matthew 16:18</a> • <a href="#">John 16:33</a>        |

## Messianic Connections

| Connection                                   | References                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Set Apart From the Womb for a Commission     | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:5</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 49:1</a> • <a href="#">Galatians 1:15</a>    |
| The Prophet Who Speaks Only What He Is Given | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:9</a> • <a href="#">Deuteronomy 18:18</a> • <a href="#">John 12:49</a>  |
| The Word That Does Not Return Empty          | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:12</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 55:11</a> • <a href="#">Matthew 24:35</a>   |
| Authority Over Nations and Kingdoms          | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:10</a> • <a href="#">Revelation 19:15</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 2:8-9</a> |
| The Face Set Like Flint                      | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:18</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 50:7</a> • <a href="#">Luke 9:51</a>        |
| “I Am With You” as the Whole Guarantee       | <a href="#">Jeremiah 1:8</a> • <a href="#">Matthew 28:20</a> • <a href="#">Hebrews 13:5-6</a>  |

## For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 1 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - verse-by-verse walkthrough of the call narrative and the two opening visions
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 1](#) - Torah-honoring perspective on the prophetic commission and its historical setting
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 1](#) - background on Josiah’s reforms and the almond-branch wordplay

## Jeremiah 1 - Opening Intro

Everything Jeremiah will endure over the next forty years is answered in advance, right here, before he has preached a single sermon. That is worth noticing. Yahweh does not call him and then explain the cost later; He tells him at the outset that the whole land will fight him, and in the same sentence tells him how it ends.

Notice also what Yahweh does with Jeremiah’s objection. “I am a child” is almost certainly true - most scholars place him in his late teens or early twenties. Yahweh never says it is false. He says it is irrelevant. The qualification was never the speaker; it was the sending.

And then two visions that set the shape of the book. An almond branch, because Yahweh is awake and watching over what He said. A pot boiling over from the north, because what He said is coming.

Before we read, hold this: a calling that reaches back before your birth is not a calling you talked yourself into, and therefore not one you can talk yourself out of.

## Jeremiah 1:1-19 (WEB)

1 The words of Jeremiah the son of Hilkiah, one of the priests who were in Anathoth in the land of Benjamin.

2 Yahweh's word came to him in the days of Josiah the son of Amon, king of Judah, in the thirteenth year of his reign.

3 It came also in the days of Jehoiakim the son of Josiah, king of Judah, to the end of the eleventh year of Zedekiah, the son of Josiah, king of Judah, to the carrying away of Jerusalem captive in the fifth month.

4 Now Yahweh's word came to me, saying,

5 "Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you. Before you were born, I sanctified you. I have appointed you a prophet to the nations."<sup>1,2</sup>

6 Then I said, "Ah, Lord Yahweh! Behold, I don't know how to speak; for I am a child."<sup>3</sup>

7 But Yahweh said to me, "Don't say, 'I am a child;' for you must go to whomever I send you, and you must say whatever I command you.

8 Don't be afraid because of them, for I am with you to rescue you," says Yahweh.

9 Then Yahweh stretched out his hand, and touched my mouth. Then Yahweh said to me, "Behold, I have put my words in your mouth."<sup>4,5</sup>

10 Behold, I have today set you over the nations and over the kingdoms, to uproot and to tear down, to destroy and to overthrow, to build and to plant."<sup>6</sup>

11 Moreover Yahweh's word came to me, saying, "Jeremiah, what do you see?" I said, "I see a branch of an almond tree."

12 Then Yahweh said to me, "You have seen well; for I watch over my word to perform it."<sup>7</sup>

13 Yahweh's word came to me the second time, saying, "What do you see?" I said, "I see a boiling cauldron; and it is tipping away from the north."

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<sup>1</sup> Cross-Reference: [Psalm 139:13-16](#) • [Isaiah 49:1](#) - formed, known, and named before birth - the servant called from the womb

<sup>2</sup> Messianic Connection: [Galatians 1:15](#) • [Deuteronomy 18:18](#) - the pattern of a life separated from the womb and a Prophet with Yahweh's words in His mouth

<sup>3</sup> Cross-Reference: [Exodus 4:10](#) - Moses raising the same objection - slow of speech, unfit for the sending

<sup>4</sup> Cross-Reference: [Isaiah 6:6-7](#) • [Ezekiel 3:1-3](#) - the prophet's mouth touched, the scroll eaten - the word placed in a man before it goes out of him

<sup>5</sup> Messianic Connection: [John 12:49](#) - the Son who spoke nothing from Himself, only what the Father commanded Him to say

<sup>6</sup> Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 18:7-10](#) • [Jeremiah 31:28](#) - the same six verbs governing Yahweh's dealings with nations - to uproot and to plant

<sup>7</sup> Cross-Reference: [Numbers 17:8](#) • [Isaiah 55:11](#) - the almond that buds first, and the word that does not return void

**14** Then Yahweh said to me, “Out of the north, evil will break out on all the inhabitants of the land.”<sup>8</sup>

**15** For, behold, I will call all the families of the kingdoms of the north,” says Yahweh. “They will come, and they will each set his throne at the entrance of the gates of Jerusalem, and against all its walls all around, and against all the cities of Judah.

**16** I will utter my judgments against them concerning all their wickedness, in that they have forsaken me, and have burned incense to other gods, and worshiped the works of their own hands.

**17** “You therefore put your belt on your waist, arise, and say to them all that I command you. Don’t be dismayed at them, lest I dismay you before them.

**18** For, behold, I have made you today a fortified city, an iron pillar, and bronze walls, against the whole land, against the kings of Judah, against its princes, against its priests, and against the people of the land.”<sup>9</sup>

**19** They will fight against you, but they will not prevail against you; for I am with you”, says Yahweh, “to rescue you.”<sup>10</sup>

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<sup>8</sup> Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 4:6](#) - the evil out of the north repeated throughout the book as Babylon draws nearer

<sup>9</sup> Cross-Reference: [Jeremiah 15:20](#) • [Isaiah 50:7](#) - the bronze wall promised again in chapter 15, and the servant’s face set like flint

<sup>10</sup> Messianic Connection: [Matthew 16:18](#) • [John 16:33](#) - the assembly the gates of Hades will not overpower, built by the One who has overcome the world

## CHAPTER 2 - The Covenant Lawsuit and the Broken Cisterns

### Key Notes

- Yahweh opens not with accusation but with memory - and with tenderness. He remembers the kindness of Israel's youth and the love of her wedding days, when she followed Him into an unsown wilderness (Jeremiah 2:1-3).
- Then the question that frames the entire lawsuit: "What unrighteousness have your fathers found in me?" The burden of proof is placed on the accused, and the silence that follows is the verdict (Jeremiah 2:4-5).
- Nobody asked "Where is Yahweh?" - not the people who forgot the wilderness deliverance, and not the priests whose whole office was to know Him. The failure runs top to bottom (Jeremiah 2:6-8).
- Yahweh calls the heavens as witnesses to something no pagan nation has ever done: exchange its gods. Israel swapped her glory for what cannot profit (Jeremiah 2:9-13).
- The two evils, stated with surgical precision: forsaking the spring of living waters, and hewing out broken cisterns that hold no water. One sin of abandonment, one of substitution (Jeremiah 2:13).
- The noble vine, planted as pure seed, has become the degenerate branches of a foreign vine - the corruption is not in the planting but in the turning (Jeremiah 2:20-21).
- The stain will not scrub out. Lye and much soap cannot reach what Yahweh sees, because the problem is not on the surface (Jeremiah 2:22).
- The chapter closes on the most dangerous sentence in it: "I have not sinned." Judgment comes not merely for the sin, but for the denial of it (Jeremiah 2:23-37).

### Key Cross-References (WEB)

| Topic                                            | References                                                                                         |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bridal Devotion in the Wilderness                | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:2</a> • <a href="#">Hosea 2:14-15</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 16:8</a>        |
| Priests Who Did Not Ask "Where Is Yahweh?"       | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:8</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 34:2-4</a> • <a href="#">Malachi 2:7-8</a>      |
| Exchanging Glory for What Cannot Profit          | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:11</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 106:20</a> • <a href="#">Romans 1:23</a>         |
| The Spring of Living Waters Forsaken             | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:13</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 36:9</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 55:1-2</a>         |
| The Noble Vine Turned Degenerate                 | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:21</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 5:1-7</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 80:8-9</a>        |
| A Stain Soap Cannot Reach                        | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:22</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 51:2</a> • <a href="#">Job 9:30-31</a>           |
| A Bride Who Forgets Her Attire                   | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:32</a> • <a href="#">Deuteronomy 32:18</a> • <a href="#">Jeremiah 18:15</a> |
| "I Have Not Sinned" - Denial as the Deeper Guilt | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:35</a> • <a href="#">Proverbs 28:13</a> • <a href="#">1 John 1:8</a>        |

## Messianic Connections

| Connection                               | References                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The First Love That Was Left             | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:2</a> • <a href="#">Revelation 2:4</a> • <a href="#">Hosea 2:14-15</a>  |
| Living Water That Never Runs Dry         | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:13</a> • <a href="#">John 4:13-14</a> • <a href="#">John 7:37-38</a>    |
| The True Vine Israel Failed to Be        | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:21</a> • <a href="#">John 15:1-5</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 5:1-7</a>     |
| Cleansing That Reaches Deeper Than Soap  | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:22</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 51:2</a> • <a href="#">1 John 1:9</a>        |
| The Bridegroom Who Remembers the Wedding | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:2</a> • <a href="#">Ephesians 5:25-27</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 54:5</a> |
| Confession as the Door Back In           | <a href="#">Jeremiah 2:35</a> • <a href="#">Proverbs 28:13</a> • <a href="#">1 John 1:9</a>    |

## For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 2 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - detailed treatment of the covenant lawsuit form and the two-evils indictment
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 2](#) - covenant-framed reading of Israel's bridal history and her turning aside
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 2](#) - exposition of the broken-cisterns image and its ancient agricultural background

## Jeremiah 2 - Opening Intro

This chapter is built like a courtroom transcript, and Yahweh argues His own case. But watch how He opens it. Not with the charge sheet - with a wedding photograph. "I remember for you the kindness of your youth, the love of your weddings." Before He says one word about what they have done, He says what they were.

Then comes the question that no one in the room can answer: what did I do wrong? Every accusation in the rest of the chapter rests on that unanswered question. They did not leave because He failed them. They left because they wanted to.

And at the center sits the image the whole book keeps returning to. Two evils - not one. They walked away from a spring that never stops running, and then did the exhausting work of chiseling storage tanks out of rock, and the tanks leaked. Nobody digs a cistern next to a living spring unless something has gone wrong in the wanting.

Before we read, carry this honestly: the labor we pour into our broken cisterns is usually the clearest measure of how far we have walked from the spring.

## Jeremiah 2:1-37 (WEB)

1 Yahweh's word came to me, saying,

2 "Go, and proclaim in the ears of Jerusalem, saying, 'Yahweh says, "I remember for you the kindness of your youth, the love of your weddings; how you went after me in the wilderness, in a land that was not sown."<sup>11,12</sup>

3 Israel was holiness to Yahweh, the first fruits of his increase. All who devour him will be held guilty. Evil will come on them,"' says Yahweh."

4 Hear Yahweh's word, O house of Jacob, and all the families of the house of Israel!

5 Yahweh says, "What unrighteousness have your fathers found in me, that they have gone far from me, and have walked after worthless vanity, and have become worthless?

6 They didn't say, 'Where is Yahweh who brought us up out of the land of Egypt, who led us through the wilderness, through a land of deserts and of pits, through a land of drought and of the shadow of death, through a land that no one passed through, and where no man lived?'

7 I brought you into a plentiful land, to eat its fruit and its goodness; but when you entered, you defiled my land, and made my heritage an abomination.

8 The priests didn't say, 'Where is Yahweh?' and those who handle the law didn't know me. The rulers also transgressed against me, and the prophets prophesied by Baal, and followed things that do not profit.<sup>13</sup>

9 "Therefore I will yet contend with you," says Yahweh, "and I will contend with your children's children.

10 For pass over to the islands of Kittim, and see; and send to Kedar, and consider diligently; and see if there has been such a thing.

11 Has a nation changed its gods, which really are no gods? But my people have changed their glory for that which does not profit.

12 "Be astonished, you heavens, at this, and be horribly afraid. Be very desolate," says Yahweh.

13 "For my people have committed two evils: they have forsaken me, the spring of living waters, and cut them out cisterns, broken cisterns, that can hold no water."<sup>14,15</sup>

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<sup>11</sup> Cross-Reference: [Hosea 2:14-15](#) • [Ezekiel 16:8](#) - the wilderness honeymoon and the covenant made when Yahweh spread His skirt over her

<sup>12</sup> Messianic Connection: [Revelation 2:4](#) - the same charge brought to Ephesus - not loss of works, but abandonment of first love

<sup>13</sup> Cross-Reference: [Ezekiel 34:2-4](#) • [Malachi 2:7-8](#) - shepherds who fed themselves and priests whose lips failed to keep knowledge

<sup>14</sup> Cross-Reference: [Psalm 36:9](#) • [Isaiah 55:1-2](#) - the fountain of life, and the invitation to come to the waters without money



**14** Is Israel a slave? Is he born into slavery? Why has he become a captive?

**15** The young lions have roared at him, and yelled. They have made his land waste. His cities are burned up, without inhabitant.

**16** The children also of Memphis and Tahpanhes have broken the crown of your head.

**17** "Haven't you brought this on yourself, in that you have forsaken Yahweh your God, when he led you by the way?

**18** Now what do you gain by going to Egypt, to drink the waters of the Shihor? Or why do you go on the way to Assyria, to drink the waters of the River?

**19** "Your own wickedness will correct you, and your backsliding will rebuke you. Know therefore and see that it is an evil and bitter thing, that you have forsaken Yahweh your God, and that my fear is not in you," says the Lord, Yahweh of Armies.

**20** "For long ago I broke off your yoke, and burst your bonds. You said, 'I will not serve;' for on every high hill and under every green tree you bowed yourself, playing the prostitute.

**21** Yet I had planted you a noble vine, a pure and faithful seed. How then have you turned into the degenerate branches of a foreign vine to me?<sup>16,17</sup>

**22** For though you wash yourself with lye, and use much soap, yet your iniquity is marked before me," says the Lord Yahweh.<sup>18</sup>

**23** "How can you say, 'I am not defiled. I have not gone after the Baals'? See your way in the valley. Know what you have done. You are a swift dromedary traversing her ways;

**24** a wild donkey used to the wilderness, that sniffs the wind in her craving. When she is in heat, who can turn her away? All those who seek her will not weary themselves. In her month, they will find her.

**25** "Keep your feet from being bare, and your throat from thirst. But you said, 'It is in vain. No, for I have loved strangers, and I will go after them.'

**26** As the thief is ashamed when he is found, so is the house of Israel ashamed; they, their kings, their princes, and their priests, and their prophets;

**27** who tell wood, 'You are my father;' and a stone, 'You have given birth to me;' for they have turned their back to me, and not their face; but in the time of their trouble they will say, 'Arise, and save us.'

**28** "But where are your gods that you have made for yourselves? Let them arise, if they can save you in the time of your trouble: for you have as many gods as you have towns, O Judah.

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<sup>15</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [John 4:13-14](#) • [John 7:37-38](#) - the water that becomes a well springing up to eternal life in whoever drinks

<sup>16</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 5:1-7](#) • [Psalm 80:8-9](#) - the vineyard given every advantage that still yielded wild grapes

<sup>17</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [John 15:1-5](#) - the true Vine succeeding precisely where the planted vine of Israel failed

<sup>18</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 51:2](#) - the plea for a washing that goes deeper than the surface of the skin

**29** “Why will you contend with me? You all have transgressed against me,” says Yahweh.

**30** “I have struck your children in vain. They received no correction. Your own sword has devoured your prophets, like a destroying lion.

**31** Generation, consider Yahweh’s word. Have I been a wilderness to Israel? Or a land of thick darkness? Why do my people say, ‘We have broken loose. We will come to you no more?’

**32** “Can a virgin forget her ornaments, or a bride her attire? Yet my people have forgotten me for days without number.”<sup>19</sup>

**33** How well you prepare your way to seek love! Therefore you have even taught the wicked women your ways.

**34** Also the blood of the souls of the innocent poor is found in your skirts. You did not find them breaking in; but it is because of all these things.

**35** “Yet you said, ‘I am innocent. Surely his anger has turned away from me.’ “Behold, I will judge you, because you say, ‘I have not sinned.’”<sup>20,21</sup>

**36** Why do you go about so much to change your ways? You will be ashamed of Egypt also, as you were ashamed of Assyria.

**37** You will also leave that place with your hands on your head; for Yahweh has rejected those in whom you trust, and you won’t prosper with them.

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<sup>19</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 32:18](#) - the Rock who fathered them, forgotten as easily as a bride forgets her ornaments

<sup>20</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Proverbs 28:13](#) - concealment forfeits mercy; confession and renunciation find it

<sup>21</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [1 John 1:9](#) - the faithfulness of God to forgive and cleanse the moment sin is actually named

## CHAPTER 3 - The Divorce Certificate and the Word “Return”

### Key Notes

- The chapter opens on a legal impossibility. Torah forbids a man from taking back a wife who has married another - and Yahweh cites the very statute against Himself before saying “yet return again to me” (Jeremiah 3:1).
- The withheld rain is named as covenant discipline, but it produced no shame: “you have had a prostitute’s forehead and you refused to be ashamed” (Jeremiah 3:2-5).
- Two sisters are compared. Backsliding Israel, the northern kingdom, was divorced and exiled; treacherous Judah watched it happen and did the same thing anyway (Jeremiah 3:6-10).
- The verdict is genuinely shocking: “Backsliding Israel has shown herself more righteous than treacherous Judah.” Open apostasy is judged less severely than pretended repentance (Jeremiah 3:10-11).
- The message is aimed north, toward a kingdom already gone into exile - people with no temple, no king, and no standing. They are the first to hear “Return” (Jeremiah 3:12).
- The only condition attached is acknowledgment: “Only acknowledge your iniquity.” Not restitution first, not reformation first - naming it (Jeremiah 3:13).
- The promise of shepherds after Yahweh’s own heart, feeding with knowledge and understanding - a direct answer to the failed shepherds of chapter 2 (Jeremiah 3:15).
- A day is coming when the ark itself will not be missed, because Jerusalem will be called Yahweh’s Throne and the nations will be gathered to it - the symbol retired because the reality has arrived (Jeremiah 3:16-18).
- The chapter ends with the response Yahweh has been waiting for since chapter 2 - a confession that finally names the sin instead of denying it (Jeremiah 3:21-25).

### Key Cross-References (WEB)

| Topic                                | References                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Divorce Statute Cited            | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:1</a> • <a href="#">Deuteronomy 24:1-4</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 50:1</a> |
| Withheld Rain as Covenant Discipline | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:3</a> • <a href="#">Deuteronomy 28:23-24</a> • <a href="#">Amos 4:7</a>  |
| Two Sisters - Israel and Judah       | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:6-11</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 23:2-4</a> • <a href="#">Hosea 4:15</a>   |
| “I Will Not Keep Anger Forever”      | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:12</a> • <a href="#">Psalm 103:8-9</a> • <a href="#">Micah 7:18-19</a>   |
| Only Acknowledge Your Iniquity       | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:13</a> • <a href="#">Proverbs 28:13</a> • <a href="#">1 John 1:9</a>     |
| Shepherds According to My Heart      | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:15</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 34:23</a> • <a href="#">Acts 20:28</a>      |
| Jerusalem Called Yahweh’s Throne     | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:17</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 2:2-3</a> • <a href="#">Zechariah 8:23</a>   |
| Judah and Israel Walking Together    | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:18</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 37:19-22</a> • <a href="#">Hosea 1:11</a>   |

## Messianic Connections

| Connection                                        | References                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The Husband Who Takes Back What the Law Would Bar | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:1</a> • <a href="#">Hosea 3:1</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 50:1</a>            |
| The Bridegroom Who Redeems His Bride              | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:14</a> • <a href="#">Ephesians 5:25-27</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 54:5</a>   |
| The Good Shepherd and the Chief Shepherd          | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:15</a> • <a href="#">John 10:11</a> • <a href="#">1 Peter 5:4</a>          |
| The Ark Retired, the Presence Arrived             | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:16</a> • <a href="#">Hebrews 9:11-12</a> • <a href="#">Revelation 21:3</a> |
| The Nations Gathered to His Name                  | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:17</a> • <a href="#">Isaiah 2:2-3</a> • <a href="#">Ezekiel 37:19-22</a>   |
| "I Will Heal Your Backsliding"                    | <a href="#">Jeremiah 3:22</a> • <a href="#">Hosea 14:1-4</a> • <a href="#">Luke 15:20</a>         |

## For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- [Enduring Word - Jeremiah 3 Commentary \(David Guzik\)](#) - the divorce imagery, the two-sisters comparison, and the call to return
- [United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 3](#) - treatment of the northern kingdom's exile and the promised regathering of both houses
- [Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 3](#) - careful handling of Deuteronomy 24 and how Yahweh addresses His own legal precedent

## Jeremiah 3 - Opening Intro

Chapter 3 begins with Yahweh quoting His own Torah against Himself. Deuteronomy 24 is explicit: a woman who leaves her husband and marries another cannot be taken back. The land would be polluted. It is an abomination.

Then, having established that He has every legal right to be done, He says: "yet return again to me."

This is the tension the whole chapter lives in, and it is not resolved by softening the law. The law stands. Something else has to give - and what gives is Yahweh Himself, who will eventually satisfy His own statute rather than ignore it.

Notice too who hears the invitation first. Not Judah, who still has the temple and the throne and the appearance of faithfulness. The word goes north, to the kingdom already carried off, already divorced, already written off. The ones with nothing left to bargain with are the ones told to come home.

And notice what is asked of them. Not a program. Not a probation period. "Only acknowledge your iniquity." After two chapters of "I have not sinned," the door opens the moment someone tells the truth.

### Jeremiah 3:1-25 (WEB)

**1** “They say, ‘If a man puts away his wife, and she goes from him, and becomes another man’s, should he return to her again?’ Wouldn’t that land be greatly polluted? But you have played the prostitute with many lovers; yet return again to me,” says Yahweh.<sup>22,23</sup>

**2** “Lift up your eyes to the bare heights, and see! Where have you not been lain with? You have sat waiting for them by the road, as an Arabian in the wilderness. You have polluted the land with your prostitution and with your wickedness.

**3** Therefore the showers have been withheld and there has been no latter rain; yet you have had a prostitute’s forehead and you refused to be ashamed.

**4** Will you not from this time cry to me, ‘My Father, you are the guide of my youth?’

**5** “‘Will he retain his anger forever? Will he keep it to the end?’ Behold, you have spoken and have done evil things, and have had your way.”

**6** Moreover, Yahweh said to me in the days of Josiah the king, “Have you seen that which backsliding Israel has done? She has gone up on every high mountain and under every green tree, and has played the prostitute there.

**7** I said after she had done all these things, ‘She will return to me;’ but she didn’t return; and her treacherous sister Judah saw it.

**8** I saw when, for this very cause, that backsliding Israel had committed adultery, I had put her away and given her a bill of divorce, yet treacherous Judah, her sister, had no fear; but she also went and played the prostitute.

**9** Because she took her prostitution lightly, the land was polluted, and she committed adultery with stones and with wood.

**10** Yet for all this her treacherous sister, Judah, has not returned to me with her whole heart, but only in pretense,” says Yahweh.

**11** Yahweh said to me, “Backsliding Israel has shown herself more righteous than treacherous Judah.”<sup>24</sup>

**12** Go, and proclaim these words toward the north, and say, ‘Return, you backsliding Israel,’ says Yahweh; ‘I will not look in anger on you; for I am merciful,’ says Yahweh. ‘I will not keep anger forever.’<sup>25</sup>

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<sup>22</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Deuteronomy 24:1-4](#) • [Isaiah 50:1](#) - the statute forbidding remarriage to a defiled wife, and the divorce Yahweh Himself issued

<sup>23</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [Hosea 3:1](#) - the prophet commanded to love an adulteress again, as Yahweh loves Israel

<sup>24</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Proverbs 28:13](#) - pretended return judged more severely than open rebellion - concealment forfeits mercy

<sup>25</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Psalm 103:8-9](#) • [Micah 7:18-19](#) - the God who does not stay angry forever and delights in loving kindness

**13** Only acknowledge your iniquity, that you have transgressed against Yahweh your God, and have scattered your ways to the strangers under every green tree, and you have not obeyed my voice,' says Yahweh."<sup>26</sup>

**14** "Return, backsliding children," says Yahweh; "for I am a husband to you. I will take one of you from a city, and two from a family, and I will bring you to Zion."<sup>27</sup>

**15** I will give you shepherds according to my heart, who will feed you with knowledge and understanding."<sup>28,29</sup>

**16** It will come to pass, when you are multiplied and increased in the land, in those days," says Yahweh, "they will no longer say, 'the ark of Yahweh's covenant!' It will not come to mind. They won't remember it. They won't miss it, nor will another be made."<sup>30</sup>

**17** At that time they will call Jerusalem 'Yahweh's Throne;' and all the nations will be gathered to it, to Yahweh's name, to Jerusalem. They will no longer walk after the stubbornness of their evil heart."<sup>31</sup>

**18** In those days the house of Judah will walk with the house of Israel, and they will come together out of the land of the north to the land that I gave for an inheritance to your fathers."<sup>32</sup>

**19** "But I said, 'How I desire to put you among the children, and give you a pleasant land, a goodly heritage of the armies of the nations!' and I said, 'You shall call me "My Father", and shall not turn away from following me.'

**20** "Surely as a wife treacherously departs from her husband, so you have dealt treacherously with me, house of Israel," says Yahweh.

**21** A voice is heard on the bare heights, the weeping and the petitions of the children of Israel; because they have perverted their way, they have forgotten Yahweh their God.

**22** Return, you backsliding children, and I will heal your backsliding. "Behold, we have come to you; for you are Yahweh our God."<sup>33,34</sup>

**23** Truly in vain is help from the hills, the tumult on the mountains. Truly the salvation of Israel is in Yahweh our God.

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<sup>26</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [1 John 1:9](#) - acknowledgment as the single condition - naming sin is what opens the door

<sup>27</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [Ephesians 5:25-27](#) • [Isaiah 54:5](#) - the Husband who gave Himself for His bride to present her without spot

<sup>28</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Ezekiel 34:23](#) - the one shepherd promised over the flock in place of those who fed themselves

<sup>29</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [John 10:11](#) • [1 Peter 5:4](#) - the Good Shepherd who lays down His life, and the Chief Shepherd yet to be revealed

<sup>30</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [Revelation 22:1-2](#) - the ark unmissed because the presence it housed dwells openly among them

<sup>31</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Isaiah 2:2-3](#) • [Zechariah 8:23](#) - all nations flowing to the mountain of Yahweh's house in the latter days

<sup>32</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Ezekiel 37:19-22](#) - the two sticks made one in Yahweh's hand - Judah and Ephraim one nation again

<sup>33</sup> **Cross-Reference:** [Hosea 14:1-4](#) - return, and the promise to heal their waywardness and love them freely

<sup>34</sup> **Messianic Connection:** [Luke 15:20](#) - the Father who saw him a long way off, and ran

**24** But the shameful thing has devoured the labor of our fathers from our youth, their flocks and their herds, their sons and their daughters.

**25** Let us lie down in our shame, and let our confusion cover us; for we have sinned against Yahweh our God, we and our fathers, from our youth even to this day. We have not obeyed Yahweh our God's voice."

## Major Themes Across Jeremiah 1-3

- A calling that predates the called - known, sanctified, and appointed before being formed
- The qualification for speaking is never eloquence but sending; the mouth is touched, not trained
- Yahweh watching over His word to perform it - the almond branch as the guarantee of the boiling pot
- A lawsuit that opens with a wedding memory and a question: what unrighteousness did you find in me?
- Two evils, not one - forsaking the spring, and the exhausting labor of digging cisterns that leak
- Denial as the deeper guilt: "I have not sinned" is what finally brings the verdict
- Mercy that cites the law it is about to overrule, and calls home a wife with no legal standing to return
- Acknowledgment as the only condition - the door opens the moment the truth is told
- The symbol retired because the reality arrives - an ark not missed, a throne in its place



## Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May the God who knew us before He formed us settle the question of whether we belong to Him, and may we stop auditioning for a place that was decided before we drew breath.

May He touch our mouths, so that what we carry to others is His word and not our opinion, and may He make us unafraid of faces.

May He keep watch over every word He has spoken to us, as the almond keeps watch over the end of winter, and may we learn to wait for its budding without doubting the tree.

May He show us the cisterns we have dug, and give us the honesty to stop repairing them, and may He lead us back to the spring we left.

May He deliver us from the words "I have not sinned," and give us instead the courage of a plain acknowledgment, knowing it is the one thing He asks before He heals.

May He be to us the Husband who reads the law aloud and then calls us home anyway, and may we not mistake His patience for indifference or His mercy for permission.

And may every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.